

Frequent *Fliers*

THE PERKS OF FOREIGN TRAVEL HAVE NEVER BEEN SO WIDELY UTILISED. THE MINISTERS OF THE UPA TRAVELLED AT WILL TO LOG ENOUGH MILES TO CIRCLE THE EARTH 256 TIMES.

■ By Shyam Lal Yadav

This is one high-flying government. In this globalised world, it is now in the nature of official business to travel to different parts of the earth, making new friends, lesser enemies and influencing people. As a rising economic power, it is perhaps more necessary than ever before to make your presence felt at global high tables and international conference podiums. But even by that yardstick, the UPA Government would seem to be in an over-drive or rather turbo-charged, its ministerial representatives raking up frequent-flier miles at a frenetic pace, this, despite the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) supposedly cracking down on bureaucrats and ministers travelling abroad at the drop of a Gandhi topi. Whether it's a case of Democracy on the Move or the New World Order, the perks of foreign travel have never been so widely utilised.

Consider this. In the 1,287 days of the UPA Government till November 30 last year, its ministers travelled an incredible 1 crore km (10 million km)-plus on trips abroad, official and personal, but mostly official. It means that the ministers made more than 256 trips around the globe, considering the earth's circumference of 40,008 km. Among the 71 ministers (excluding the prime minister) who went on foreign trips during their tenure, 47 ministers spent over Rs 27 crore. The bill would be much higher, taking into account the fact that the other ministers did not provide details of their expenditure. This, of course, does not include the expenses incurred by Indian embassies abroad which run up substantial bills hiring limousines and providing other services to visiting ministers. At least 12 of the total 78 ministers travelled more than 2.5 lakh km each in the last three-and-a-half years.

Not that they did anything illegal or shady: none of the trips (we hope!)

Seventy-one of the 78 UPA ministers (besides prime minister) have made 786 foreign trips spending about 3,798 days and travelling 1.02 crore km in 1,287 days.